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On the topic :

«The Role of the U.S. Party Polarisation in the U.S. Foreign Policy Formation in Relation to Russia within the Context of the 2022-2024 Ukraine Crisis»

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1. Introduction

1.1. Contextualisation & Topic Outline

It is quite conspicuous that the international system has undergone seismic shifts over the past several years. From the tense geopolitical landscape to the rapidly changing world order, the international arena is splitting into two separate political camps, driven, among other things, by the Ukraine crisis. The geopolitical crisis has reignited hostilities between the United States and Russia, with the former undertaking harsh measures vis-à-vis the latter since 2022 with a view to ending the Ukraine crisis. With an arguable New Cold War presently unfolding between the West and the East (Achcar, 2023), the world is largely divided between those supporting Russia and those supporting the West's efforts to suppress Russia. The domestic political landscape of the U.S. is no exception in this regard, with the polarisation between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party dividing the country alongside two divergent lines of reasoning, which has substantial implications for how the question of Ukraine is approached. It is only prudent, therefore, to delve into the polarised political scene of the U.S. in order to understand the significance of its impact on the foreign policy vis-à-vis Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis.

Firstly, it is notable that the relations between the United States and Russia have undergone numerous shifts over the course of history, particularly, since the dissolution of the USSR in 1991. Ranging from attempting a full-fledged integration of Russia into the Western-led world order to being completely unable to find common ground on which to build cooperative relations, the U.S. and Russia share a complex history that is filled with certain points of contention that seem to resurface time and again. One of such contested points is the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation that dates back to the signing of the North Atlantic Treaty on April 4th, 1949 (Henrikson, 1980) and which emerged as a response of the U.S. to the perceived communist threat within

the context of the Cold War. While decades have passed since its origination (during which the Cold War ended and the USSR dissolved), NATO has continued to influence the U.S.-Russia relations well into the 21st century. Inability to find common ground and to reconcile their markedly different stances on the post-Soviet space makes Russia and the U.S. locked in a conflict that underpins their relations as a whole. Not long after the dawn of the 21st century, the terrorist attacks of September 11th, 2001 fell upon the United States. With the Bush administration launching the War on Terror, Russia was initially eager to cooperate with the U.S. in fighting international terrorism. Yet, the U.S. foreign policy approach during these years became irreconcilable with Russia's perception of the way things ought to be done in the international system. Hence, such a discrepancy prompted a deterioration of relations between the U.S. and Russia that would largely come to define the nature of their relations for decades to come. As such, from the 2008 Bucharest Summit that signified a drastic divergence in their respective stances on the post-Soviet space to the 2009 - 2012 policy of "reset" that indicated an attempt to ameliorate the relations, the U.S. and Russia ultimately clashed in their interests with regard to the post-Soviet space and NATO, leaving little room for cooperation.

Secondly, with regard to the expansion of NATO into the post-Soviet space, Ukraine has emerged as an overarching concern for both Russia and the U.S. (with the latter willing to support Ukraine's accession to NATO and the former aiming to maintain its dominance in the region). This particular tug-of-war dates back to the 2003-2004 Colour Revolutions, with the 2004 Orange Revolution being of specific relevance to this paper, as it represented a clash of interests between the U.S and Russia over the government in Ukraine. Having won the elections, which were considered to be fraudulent (Karatnycky, 2005), pro-Russian V. Yanukovich was not accepted as a legitimate president of Ukraine, leading to the ultimate installation of the

pro-Western V. Yushchenko, which Russia considered to be as an interference of the West in its near abroad. Similarly, the 2013 Euromaidan, which resulted in the installation of the pro-Western government and increased the likelihood of Ukraine joining NATO, aggravated Russia, culminating in the incorporation of Crimea into the Russian Federation in 2014. The apex of the conflict, however, would not be reached until February of 2022, when Russia began undertaking measures to prevent further spread of the Western alliance in the region which Russia considers as its sphere of influence. The 2022 Ukraine crisis, as such, would set in motion a cascade of events that would provoke major shifts in international relations, ultimately defining the new international order.

Particularly, as the Ukraine crisis of 2022 reignited hostilities between the U.S. and Russia, the former has swiftly reformulated its foreign policy vis-à-vis the latter. While it might seem as a mere response to a systemic shift, other variables, such as the U.S. party polarisation, may have accounted for the way the U.S. foreign policy has been redesigned. Being a powerful, multifaceted phenomenon in politics, the consequences of polarisation do, indeed, extend way beyond the domestic political scene of the United States. Notably, the ideological divergence that drives the Democratic Party and the Republican Party is, in turn, driving the U.S. foreign policy, influencing the U.S. approach to both Russia and Ukraine. The extent to which it is doing so, however, is not so transparent and requires thorough research on the topic. <u>This paper addresses the role of party polarisation on the U.S. foreign policy formation in order to shed light on the extent to which polarisation drives the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia.</u> As Ikenberry (2022, p.69) has put it, "...the outside world has a greater stake in what happens in the United States", meaning that the internal dynamics of the U.S. have far-reaching consequences for the world, making it vital to understand the precise way in which it exudes influence on the conduct of foreign affairs.

Therefore, the aforementioned events serve as a testimony to the fact that the world is living through a significant, course-altering period in history. The current Ukraine crisis has once again led to a clash of interests between the U.S. (alongside its Western allies) and Russia, with the U.S. having undertaken numerous measures in its foreign policy to suppress Russia. While this period bears resemblance to the period of the Cold War in that the world has once more become divided along two divergent lines of reasoning (with those supporting Ukraine and those supporting Russia), this period is still markedly different in some respects. Notably, the unprecedented level of domestic party polarisation in the U.S. has to be taken into account as it may have exerted significant influence on the way the U.S. conducted its foreign policy in relation to Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis.

1.2. Literature Review

1.2.1. U.S. Party Polarisation

The notion of polarisation is far from being new on the political landscape of the United States, which accounts for a myriad of studies that have been conducted on this topic. The U.S. party polarisation, in particular, has attracted substantial attention from scholars, largely owing to an exponential increase in the divergence between Democrats and Republicans over the past years. Due to it being influenced by numerous external and internal factors, different aspects of polarisation have been widely researched by scholars, some of whose works are outlined below.

Prior to delving into party polarisation in the U.S., it is worth looking at how the issue of polarisation per se has been approached by scholars so far. Hetherington (2009), for example, distinguishes between elite and mass polarisation, stating that the former does not necessarily correspond with the latter. Alternatively, Van Der Veen (2021) cautions against using a narrow

definition of polarisation, offering, instead, a four-dimensional view of polarisation. The author explores an interplay between affective, ideological, mass and elite polarisation, stating that all of them have to be considered to render a comprehensive understanding of polarisation (Van Der Veen, 2021). One inference that can be made from this is that polarisation is a multifaceted phenomenon, interpretation of which is dependent upon the nature of study and research.

Moving on to the party polarisation in the United States, scholars tend to research both the causes and the consequences of polarisation within U.S. politics. In their study of polarisation, Hare & Poole (2014) find that the U.S. political scene is highly polarised, attributing this to the growing partisan divergence in terms of ideology and to the exposure to new social and cultural issues. More particularly, Caro (2016) explores the causes of polarisation in the U.S., stating that it is the long-term trends that have shaped the current accelerating polarisation, replacing bipartisan consensus that is essential for laws to be swiftly passed. One reason behind this lies in voters moving away from the political center, making it less feasible to reach consensus (Caro, 2016). Similarly, Pildes (2011) researches the causes of hyperpolarisation in the U.S., claiming that the political center is dissipating both among politicians and voters. The author aims to identify whether polarisation is inherent in the U.S. democracy or it has a fleeting nature, ultimately concluding that, being caused by deeply-rooted structural problems, polarisation is, indeed, inherent in American politics (Pildes, 2011). Therefore, it is evident that the notion of polarisation permeates the political scene of the U.S., with the party polarisation being driven by a disappearing political center and the emergence of novel cultural and social issues.

Being such a key feature of contemporary U.S. politics, party polarisation has a significant impact on how the government functions. In the seminal work on

polarisation, Lee (2015) traces the implications of the U.S. party polarisation on the efficiency of the U.S. government and the ways in which polarisation negatively affects the executive, the legislative and the judicial branches of the government. More specifically, Jones (2001) cited polarisation as a key factor in the production of a legislative gridlock, which represents a policy stalemate with the legislative process being suspended and the Congress being unable to pass policies. This is closely related to the way polarisation influences the U.S. foreign policy formation. Particularly, Kalėda (2023) states that the U.S. domestic polarisation is detrimental to the U.S. foreign policy as it damages its credibility and divides Republicans and Democrats over such issues as aid to Ukraine, while preserving bipartisan consensus on the phenomenon "rise of China". Similarly, Tama (2024) claims that while democrats and republicans are polarised, bipartisan consensus is still present as the parties cooperate in a myriad of ways, most prominently on certain international issues. Notably, the aforementioned authors have focused on polarisation as a predominantly negative phenomenon that affects the efficiency of the U.S. government. An alternate view on polarisation, however, was proposed by Abramovitz (2010), who claims that polarisation need not be an inherently negative force. The author, on the contrary, claims that the greater the polarisation between the elites (and, consequently, parties), the clearer the ideological choice presented to people (Abramovitz, 2010). Thus, while the U.S. party polarisation can be viewed in either a positive or a negative light, the latter view presumably dominates in academia, with polarisation being often cited as a cause of legislative impasse and foreign policy that lacks credibility.

To conclude, polarisation is a concept that can be utilised in various contexts due to its multidimensional nature. Yet, a large pool of work on polarisation particularly concerns the U.S. political scene, where polarisation between Democrats and Republicans has dominated the political agenda over the past

several decades. The causes and the implications of the U.S. party polarisation on the efficiency of the legislative branch of the U.S. government, particularly with regard to the U.S. foreign policy, have been studied plentifully. However, what has not been studied in such intricate detail is the way polarisation plays a role in the formation of the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia within the Ukraine crisis. Considering the omnipresent nature of polarisation in the U.S., it can be presumed that it exudes considerable influence on the way the issue is approached.

1.2.2. U.S.-Russia relations & U.S. Foreign Policy vis-à-vis Russia

The United States and Russia share a complex history that is rich in events which, at times, drastically altered the following course of their interactions. Below are some of the works and studies that delve into the U.S.-Russia relations, ranging, notably, from the consequences of the dissolution of the USSR in 1991 to the role of NATO in the U.S.-Russia relations, with a specific focus on the Cold War legacy that continues to influence the bilateral relations between the two states. Notably, the post-Cold War relations (from 1991 up to the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis) between the U.S. and Russia can be divided into several stages that have been widely researched in academia, namely: cooperation and optimistic outlook on the bilateral relations with a subsequent gradual deterioration (1991-1999), the relations oscillating between cooperation and confrontation (2000-2008), the 'reset' of relations (2009-2012), deterioration of the relations (2012-2021), and ultimate decoupling (2022-2024).

Firstly, the dissolution of the USSR in 1991 served as a catalyst behind a new strand of the U.S.-Russia relations, initially considered to be imbued with optimism about the future of their relations. The hopes of this period, however, gradually gave way to tensions and confrontation. According to Smeltz et al. (2016), this period was, indeed, viewed by many as a prospect of

improvement in the U.S.-Russia relations, which ultimately failed to manifest. Numerous studies, as such, explore this new strand of bilateral U.S.-Russia relations with a specific focus on why sustainable cooperation was not fully achieved between the two states. This view is largely supported by Bugayova (2019), who stated that, becoming the first president of the newly born Russian state, Boris Yeltsin aimed at promoting democracy and ameliorating the relations between the U.S. and Russia. Still, the Russian foreign policy was gradually becoming more assertive and less conducive to cooperation with the U.S. over the mid-1990s, with the largest blow to the relations being dealt by NATO's decision to intervene in Yugoslavia in 1999 (Bugayova, 2019). Zelikow (1994), while sharing the initial hopes for the U.S.-Russia cooperation, supported both by president George H. W. Bush and president Bill Clinton, also stressed how quickly this optimism had dissipated. Focusing on the U.S. foreign policy specifically, Zelikow (1994) states that, while the Clinton administration took pride in their successful foreign policy towards Russia, the emphasis on an internal Russian reform was quite precarious, with the clash of interests between the U.S. and Russia ultimately prevailing. Furthermore, by starting with a sequential history of the turbulent U.S.-Russia relations in the post-Cold War period, Rumer & Sokolsky (2019) go on to argue that the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia exemplified rigid consistency since 1991, leaving little hope for durable cooperation. The authors claim that despite a change of several U.S. administrations over this period, the U.S. consistently refused to fully accept Russia and its domestic affairs, emphasising democracy promotion and the primacy of NATO, causing the deterioration of relations (Rumer & Sokolsky, 2019). By contrast, for Rostow (1992), who emphasised the congruence between the structure of the international system after the collapse of the USSR and the U.S. foreign policy goals, it was evident that the U.S. would achieve those goals swiftly if it were to adopt an active foreign policy stance. Moreover, Katz (2014) highlights the fact that each of the post-Cold War U.S. administrations has

attempted to ameliorate relations and partner with Russia. Instead, however, despite adopting active stances, neither American nor Russian foreign policy goals vis-à-vis each other were fully achieved after the collapse of the Soviet Union. One of the reasons was an inability to agree on the post-Soviet space and the role of NATO in a post-Cold war world.

Secondly, between 2000 and 2008 the nature of the U.S.-Russia relations tended to alternate between confrontation and cooperation. Tsygankov (2007) distinguishes this period into two separate policies, pursued by Russian president Vladimir Putin, the first one focusing on pragmatism and maintaining great power status, the second, starting around the mid-2000s, focusing on an assertive stance of Russia in the world and a growing critical stance towards the U.S. foreign policy. As the start of the 21st century brought the terrorist attacks of September 11th, 2001, Gladkyy (2003) states that it prompted an intensification of the U.S.-Russia relations, with the two countries agreeing to cooperate in fighting international terrorism. Moreover, the Joint Declaration, signed by George W. Bush and Vladimir Putin in 2002, highlighted the nations' dedication to reciprocal, open, and trustworthy relations, contributing to the establishment of the NATO-Russia Council and ameliorating the NATO-Russia relations to a previously unseen degree (Gladkyy, 2003). While this improvement in the U.S.-Russia relations seemed to eliminate the remnants of the Cold War logic, this notion was soon disproved by the events that followed. Particularly, Lynch (2018) states that the U.S.-Russia relations have been experiencing gradual deterioration approximately since 2003, with a strong bipartisan consensus in the U.S. about the impossibility of ameliorating relations with Russia. Several reasons may account for neither Russia nor the U.S. willing to cooperate, with one of the most cited ones in academia being the Orange Revolution, which, according to Herd (2005), was perceived by Russia as a revolution instigated by the West. This notion strengthened to such an extent that it started shaping

Russia's foreign policy, particularly with regard to the post-Soviet space (Herd, 2005). As such, the tensions over the post-Soviet space, widely researched in academia, have started to dominate in the U.S.-Russia relations. Particularly, Matsaberidze (2015) focuses on the Russian emphasis on the primacy in the 'near abroad' with the tensions over the prospects of Georgia and Ukraine entering NATO being at the heart of confrontation between the West and Russia in 2008. Similarly, Lazarević (2009) focuses on the role of NATO and the potential membership of Georgia and Ukraine in the U.S.-Russia relations, with a particular focus on the geopolitical position of the organisation. One inference that can be made from these studies is that in spite of attempts to ameliorate relations between 2000 and 2008, the relations were still imbued with the remnants of the Cold War and its legacy.

In a stark departure from the previous course of action, the U.S. and Russia launched a policy of 'reset' in 2009-2012, promoted by the Obama administration and Russian president Dmitry Medvedev. This period aimed at increasing cooperation between the U.S. and Russia, alongside eliminating hostilities between the two states. By stating that the improvement of the U.S.-Russia relations is directly related to the emergence of novel agreements and cooperation on global issues, Charap (2013) notes that the period of 'reset' was one of the most productive ones in the history of the U.S.-Russia relations. Particularly, Charap (2013) cites numerous joint achievements of the two states, among which are the New START treaty, cooperation on the question of Afghanistan and the installation of the Bilateral Presidential Commission to foster cooperation on a myriad of matters. What is more, Roberts (in Tsygankov, 2018, p.245) states that the period of 'reset' promoted better ties between Russia and NATO, in addition to president Obama recognising Russia's importance to the U.S. and its goals. While this period was, indeed, viewed as an opportunity to improve the U.S.-Russia relations, scholars such as Ratti (2013) were sceptical of the true intentions of the two

states. More particularly, Ratti (2013) stated that while certain goals, such as the New START Treaty and the operations of the NATO-Russia Council, were attained, a genuine attempt to cooperate was present neither on the U.S. side nor on the Russian side. Having started with renewed hopes for the U.S.-Russia cooperation, the policy of 'reset', as such, had a relatively fleeting, unsustainable nature, as is evident from the next period in the U.S.-Russia relations.

With the return of Vladimir Putin to the presidency in 2012 the bilateral relations between the U.S. and Russia started to deteriorate further, mostly, according to Charap (2013), due to president Putin's non-acceptance of the U.S. foreign policy trajectory and, hence, his reluctance to cooperate with the U.S. More particularly, Roberts (in Tsygankov, 2018, p.247) states that the tensions over NATO have once again reemerged as a point of contention between the U.S. and Russia, with virtually no cooperation having been achieved between the two states since Vladimir Putin's return to power in 2012. One of the most seminal moments in the U.S.-Russia relations came in 2014 with Russia incorporating Crimea, which, according to Matsaberidze (2015), was a manifestation of Russia's security concerns over the prospects of Ukraine joining NATO. Furthermore, Katz (2020) states that it was the incorporation of Crimea in 2014 by Russia that has effectively put an end to the policy of 'reset' and any attempts at cooperation, arguably leading to the revival of the Cold War rivalry. What is more, the relations were further aggravated by the alleged interference of Russia into the 2016 elections in the United States, making it virtually impossible to manage the relations amicably (Lynch, 2018). While searching for the key causes behind such a negative chain of events, scholars such as Smeltz et al. (2016) focus on the perception as one of the key determinants of the relations' deterioration, citing distrust as one of the most fundamental reasons behind an inability of the U.S. and Russia to achieve long-lasting cooperation. Such distrust is, once again, most

likely a remnant of the tense Cold War ideological rivalry, which is also plentifully researched in academia. Scholars such as Newlin et al. (2020) and Avdaliani (2017), for example, use the Cold War as a point of reference in their research, stating that in 2020 and 2017, respectively, relations between Russia and the U.S. have been at their nadir since the end of the Cold War in 1991. Notably, Sümer (2020) states that even though the Cold War ended, its legacy proved to be long-lasting, impacting the future of relations between the U.S. and Russia. Therefore, it is evident that the period between 2012 and 2021 was filled with numerous obstacles that prevent the U.S. and Russia from achieving durable and mutually-beneficial cooperation, not least owing to the legacy of the Cold War that continues to influence their relations.

Finally, while the U.S. and Russia have been at odds for the most part of the 21st century, the ultimate decoupling between them did not occur until the 2022 Ukraine crisis. Having provoked major shifts in the post-Cold War order, the 2022 Ukraine crisis attracted substantial attention from scholars who have been studying the U.S.-Russia relations for decades. Notably, these scholars can be divided into two separate lines of reasoning, the first one adhering to the realist principles and the second one adhering to the liberal principles. Notably, in discussing the 2022 Ukraine crisis, one of the most prominent proponents of the realist paradigm, Mearsheimer (2022), reviews the causes of the crisis. By contradicting the prevalent Western narrative that Vladimir Putin is to blame for the start of the crisis, Mearsheimer (2022) claims that, instead, the West largely bears responsibility for the crisis, with the expansion of NATO being at the heart of the problem. A year later, Mearsheimer (2023) further researched the ongoing crisis, stating that the possibility of a peace agreement is non-existent between Russia and Ukraine (alongside the West), due to the existential nature of the crisis, where losing is not an acceptable option for either of the sides. Similarly, by juxtaposing the views of realists and the views of liberals on NATO and Ukraine, Walt (2022)

takes a realist stance on the crisis, claiming that the expansion of NATO has inevitably generated the crisis in the first place. According to Walt (2022), it is an inability of liberals to acknowledge the realist paradigm (in this case Russia's security concerns over NATO enlargement) that spurs the crisis. In stark contrast to this view and adhering to the liberal paradigm, Kramer (2022) criticises Russia for having started the 2022 Ukraine crisis, centering his argument around democratic values, emphasising how vital it is that the West defeats Russia so as to preserve the ideals of democracy. In a similar liberal fashion, Fukuyama (2022) positions the 2022 Ukraine conflict within a broader crisis of the liberal world order, stating that even if the conflict is resolved in favour of the West, the Western order will still face substantial hardships, overcoming which is an everlasting process. Therefore, it is evident that the 2022 Ukraine crisis drastically divides scholars in their stances on the crisis, with some adhering to the realist paradigm and others to the liberal strand of thought.

Overall, the U.S.-Russia relations after the collapse of the USSR can be categorised into five distinct stages, ranging from the initial hopes of cooperation and mutually beneficial relations to the ultimate decoupling between the two states. Most of the studies that research the U.S.-Russia relations, however, primarily focus on the reasons that prevented the two states from bettering their relations in the post-Cold War world. The post-Soviet space and the role of NATO are the most cited factors in the deterioration of the bilateral relations between the U.S. and Russia. Despite widely researched attempts to cooperate (fighting international terrorism and the policy of 'reset'), the feelings of mutual mistrust have ultimately pervaded the relations. The recent 2022 Ukraine crisis has further aggravated the U.S.-Russia relations, leaving the two states unable to achieve a long-lasting cooperation.

1.3. Research Question & Hypothesis

The literature review highlights the fact that while an extensive pool of research has been conducted on the U.S. party polarisation and the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia (including the context of the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis), a gap exists between the extensively researched U.S. party polarisation and the consequent U.S. approach to the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis.

Particularly, it is not clear how, if at all, the U.S. polarisation influences the way the U.S. approaches Russia and the Ukraine crisis, with the U.S. arguably targeting Russia as a way of easing the pressure on Ukraine. What is more, most studies that cover the recent crisis in detail are relatively outdated, with little research having been conducted on the period between 2022 and 2024. Thus, taking into account the available debates on the U.S. party polarisation and the U.S. foreign policy vis-à-vis Russia, alongside the discovered research gap, the following research question was formulated: To what extent do the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge with regard to the Ukraine crisis and how, if at all, did it influence the formation of the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the current Ukraine crisis in 2022-2024? To answer this question, the following hypothesis will be tested: The views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge significantly with regard to the Ukraine crisis, with this discrepancy having been a prominent intervening variable in the formation of the U.S foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis between 2022-2024.

The paper, therefore, will aim at filling the research gap by identifying the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party on the Ukraine crisis alongside determining the ways in which this could have impacted the

formation of the U.S. foreign policy initiatives vis-à-vis Russia over the period of 2022-2024.

1.4. Methodology & Conceptualisation

In order to trace the influence of the U.S. party polarisation on the U.S. foreign policy vis-à-vis Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis, the methods, alongside theoretical and chronological frameworks, are outlined below. In addition, this section aims at conceptualising the key notions used in this paper, primarily concerning polarisation and its various definitions as well as the core ideas from neoclassical realism, as this theory aims at taking into account both systemic factors and internal dynamics of a state to explain the formulation of foreign policy.

1.4.1. Theoretical Framework

For the purposes of this paper, the primary theoretical framework applied is neoclassical realism, which, apart from considering the international system and its incentives, helps in identifying the way domestic variables of a state influence this state's foreign policy.

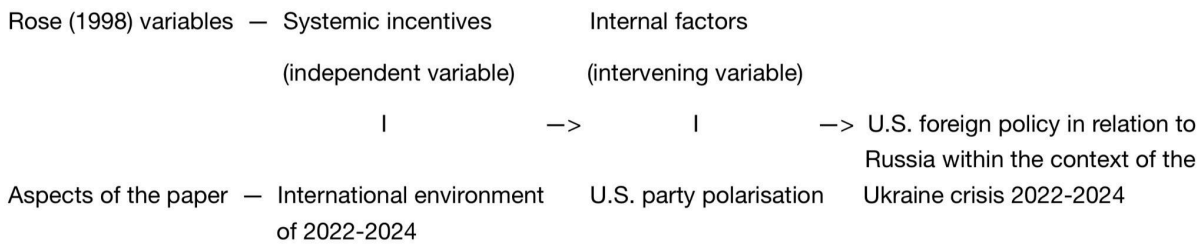
Initially introduced by Rose (1998), this theory is generally viewed as a modified version of structural realism, whereby it takes some of the premises of structural realism and ameliorates it in order to render a comprehensive understanding of what drives foreign policy decisions of states in response to external obstacles and incentives. Among four theories of foreign policy identified by Rose (1998), *innenpolitik* theories that view domestic affairs of a state as the sole determinant of its foreign policy are, according to the author, largely oversimplified and misguided. The reason behind this oversimplification is the neglect of the international system and its influence on a state's foreign policy. What Rose (1998) proposed, instead, is to take into consideration both the international system and the systemic incentives

(independent variable) and the internal factors (intervening variable) when researching the foreign policy of a state. This approach to foreign policy was termed “neoclassical realism” (Rose, 1998). Notably, some scholars divide neoclassical realism into two distinct subtypes. In their research, Ripsman et al. (2016) identified Type I neoclassical realism that merely aims at bettering structural realism via the introduction of domestic variables and type II neoclassical realism that focuses on systemic incentives alongside domestic variables, with the latter being associated with what Rose (1998) initially proposed.

This paper primarily focused on Type II neoclassical realism as it aids in explaining the ways in which the U.S. foreign policy has been influenced both by systemic incentives of the international environment of 2022-2024 and by an intervening variable of domestic party polarisation within the United States.

Figure 1

Key Aspects of the Paper Through the Prism of Neoclassical Realism of Rose (1998)



Note: *Adapted from Rose (1998)*

This figure illustrates the relationship between the variables proposed by Rose (1998) in neoclassical realism and the aspects of the thesis. This was done to showcase the topic of the thesis through the prism of neoclassical realism and to prove the theory’s applicability to the topic and the research question.

1.4.2. Methods

For the purposes of collecting and analysing data, relevant to the research paper, qualitative methods have been implemented throughout the paper. In particular, information and data were collected from secondary and primary sources. To provide an example of primary sources, think tanks, such as Pew Research Center, were used to collect statistics and raw data on the topic, alongside speeches and debates of the U.S. politicians. With regard to the secondary sources, a wide array of books and scholarly articles have been researched to introduce an academic debate on the research topic as well as to provide a thorough historical and theoretical background. The primary method used in this paper is a qualitative method of narrative analysis. This method, according to Oppermann & Spencer in Mello & Ostermann (2023), is widely implemented in the realm of Foreign Policy Analysis as it aids in identifying the views and attitudes of politicians with regard to issues within the realm of foreign policy. By focusing on organising and constructing a certain narrative, this method can render a comprehensive understanding of the views of decision-makers, who are, in most cases, interpret events and their context through the prism of a particular narrative. Being applicable to the research question, narrative analysis has been implemented with a view to researching polarisation between the Democratic and the Republican Parties, comparing the contrasting narratives of the Democrats and the Republicans on the Ukraine crisis and Russia, tracing how, if at all, polarisation between them influences the production of foreign policy decisions.

Figure 2

Coding Scheme for the Narratives within The Research Paper

Setting	Characterization	Emplotment
2022 Ukraine crisis, U.S. party polarisation	Democrats: Kamala Harris (2024 U.S. presidential nominee), Tim Walz (2024 U.S. vice presidential nominee)	The story unfolds in the win-lose setting of the 2024 U.S. presidential race
2024 presidential and vice presidential debates & 2024 Democratic and Republican convention speeches	Republicans: Donald Trump (2024 U.S. presidential nominee), JD Vance (2024 U.S. vice presidential nominee)	Objectives of foreign policy of Democrats: defend democratic values
		Objectives of foreign policy of Republicans: increase national strength
		Attributing blame for foreign policy failures to each other

Note: Adapted from Oppermann & Spencer in Mello & Ostermann (2023)

Figure 2 illustrates a coding scheme, where the interplay of three key components, namely, setting, characterization, and emplotment, produces a narrative. Each component is filled with the data relevant to the research question, focusing on Democrats and Republicans within the context of the Ukraine crisis as well as the presidential and vice presidential debates within the 2024 U.S. presidential elections, alongside convention speeches. By constructing and comparing the narrative of Democrats and the narrative of Republicans with regard to the crisis and Russia, via the presidential and the vice presidential debates and speeches, the approach to the Ukraine crisis and the consequent foreign policy towards Russia can be determined.

What is more, a mixture of inductive and deductive reasoning is used to form a general understanding of how specific nuances of party polarisation impact the broader tendencies of the U.S. foreign policy (particularly in relation to Russia in the context of the current Ukraine crisis in 2022-2024) and to understand how the application of a theoretical framework (neoclassical realism) can enhance the understanding of the nuances of the topic at large.

The aforementioned methods allowed to thoroughly analyse the existing literature on the topic and to produce a cohesive answer to the stated above research question by tracing the correlation between the U.S. party polarisation and the U.S. foreign policy decisions.

1.4.3. Conceptualization

Next, a pool of concepts will be identified that have been used throughout this paper. Considering the fact that the research mainly revolves around the concept of polarisation, most of the concepts are related specifically to it, with a few notions regarding the theoretical framework and the Ukraine crisis having also been introduced.

Firstly, polarisation can be defined as an ideological divide between two particular groups that hold polar opposite, extreme views on specific issues. Being deeply rooted in spatial theory by Downs (1957), who posits that voters are positioned alongside a one-dimensional left-right spectrum, it is quite common to view polarisation in the form of this spectrum, where the greater the distance between two opposite poles, the greater the polarisation is. Additionally, apart from ideological polarisation, there is also a notion of affective polarisation, introduced by Iyengar et al. (2012), and which refers to an emotional divide between the in-party group and out-party group, where a positive feeling towards one's own party goes hand-in-hand with a negative feeling towards an opposing party. Here, partisanship plays a vital role on which people tend to build their social identities (McCarty, 2019). A distinction should be made, however, between polarisation and partisanship, in order not to confuse these two terms, as the former refers to extremity of views, while the latter refers to a strong party loyalty and is closely related to affective polarisation. While this paper primarily focuses on ideological polarisation, partisanship and affective polarisation are also taken into account as contributing to party polarisation factors. Additionally, a similar concept of

bipartisanship (or bipartisan consensus) is referred to in this paper and, in the context of this paper, it can be defined as a consensus between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party on a specific issue. Polarisation may be found in a plethora of various contexts, however, for the purposes of this paper, polarisation is viewed specifically in the political context of the U.S. party politics. Party polarisation, therefore, can be defined as "situations where polarisation is organised around parties" (McCarty, 2019). In the case of the U.S., in particular, these parties are the Democratic Party, associated with liberal values, and the Republican Party, associated with conservative values, that tend to take contrasting stances on the issues. Thus, this paper looks into the U.S. party polarisation as an ideological divergence between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party, with this divergence being exacerbated via affective polarisation and partisanship.

Secondly, when it comes to the theoretical framework of neoclassical realism (Rose, 1998), certain key concepts, relevant to this paper, are outlined in Figure 1. Of particular importance to this paper are the systemic incentives (that serve as an independent variable) in the form of the 2022-2024 international environment and internal factors (that serve as an intervening variable) in the form of the U.S. party polarisation. The application of neoclassical realism, as such, presupposes viewing such an internal factor as polarisation as an intervening variable in the production of a foreign policy of a state.

In addition, several concepts have to be outlined with regard to the Ukraine crisis and the U.S.-Russia relations within the context of this crisis. Particularly, this research paper uses a concept by Hoffman (2007), termed hybrid warfare, to describe the characteristics of the nature of a confrontation between the U.S. and Russia with regard to the Ukraine crisis. Hybrid warfare, according to Hoffman (2007), is essentially an amalgamation of both

conventional and non-conventional components of warfare. What is more, the nature of the U.S.-Russia confrontation within the context of the Ukraine crisis is described by the concept of a proxy war, which, in this case, is characterised by an absence of a direct military confrontation between the U.S. and Russia and a presence of the U.S. support for Ukraine.

1.4.4. Scope of the Paper

Within the scope of this paper is party polarisation in the U.S. between 2022 and 2024, and its influence on the foreign policy decisions over this period in relation to Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis. While the paper briefly discusses the nuances of polarisation itself, the origins and causes of polarisation are largely beyond the scope of this research and will not be considered in detail. What is discussed in detail is the way in which divergent views of Democrats and Republicans, expressed in the polarisation between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party in the U.S., influence the U.S. foreign policy stance towards Russia in 2022-2024, considering the context of the Ukraine crisis. Additionally, for the purposes of providing a thorough historical background, the U.S.-Russia relations themselves are considered with a specific focus on the period between the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 and the start of the Ukraine crisis in 2022.

1.4.5. Potential Shortcomings & Limitations

As for potential shortcomings, it is possible that, even if established, a causal relationship between the U.S. polarisation and the alterations in the U.S. foreign policy decisions towards Russia may not be directly proven as other factors may also be at play here. In addition, due to the chronological framework that spans recent years, a further potential problem may be that of a lack of data and thorough research on the U.S. foreign policy decisions and tactics in relation to Russia.

1.4.6. Paper Outline

The rest of the paper is organised as follows. Section two provides historical and theoretical background of the subtopics to set the backbone of the topic. Democratic and Republican narratives with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia are coded, constructed, compared and analysed in Section three via the application of the method of narrative analysis. Research results are presented and analysed in Section four, alongside discussion, limitations, shortcomings and concluding remarks on the conducted research, followed by the final conclusion in Section five.

2. Historical & Theoretical Background

2.1. U.S. Party Polarisation as a Divisive Political Force

Few notions within the political scene of the United States have had such a divisive effect on politics as party polarisation. Historically, the structure of the U.S. political landscape presupposed a dichotomy that manifested itself in a two-party system. This non-proportional system, composed of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party, inherently juxtaposes the views of Democrats and Republicans, putting them in a situation of a nearly permanent ideological confrontation. Being one of the key features of the U.S. politics and having been increasing in intensity over the past decades, party polarisation largely came to define not only the domestic policy of the U.S., but also its foreign policy. As such, party polarisation is a somewhat powerful phenomenon, whose intricacies have to be closely examined in order to understand the way in which it exudes influence on foreign policy decisions.

Firstly, to reiterate what has been stated above, polarisation implies an ideological divide between two particular groups who hold polar opposite views on the issues, and, in accordance with the spatial theory by Downs (1957), can be positioned alongside a left-right spectrum. In the case of the U.S. political landscape, the left side of the spectrum is represented by the Democratic Party, while the right side is represented by the Republican Party, with a substantial divergence existing between them. This divergence, manifesting itself in the notion of party polarisation, can be attributed to a plethora of factors, including the diverse ideologies and values, the concept of affective polarisation (Iyengar et al., 2012), which generates both positive feelings towards one's own party and negative sentiments towards the opposing party, as well as the notion of partisanship, which is driven by people's strong bias towards one's own party and a prejudiced view of the opposing party (McCarty, 2019). While polarisation may, indeed, be subdivided into ideological and affective one, this paper primarily looks into

ideological polarisation with a minor emphasis on affective polarisation as a contributing factor. Being closely related to affective polarisation, partisanship is also within the scope of this paper as it is a crucial component of party polarisation. To sum up, the U.S. party polarisation is an expression of the ideological divide between the left-wing Democratic Party and the right-wing Republican Party, which may also be aggravated by partisanship and affective polarisation.

Secondly, the recent trend has been that of an exponentially rising party polarisation within the United States, largely splitting the country into two political camps. Starting from the 1970s, both Pew Research Center (2022) and McCarty (2019) indicate a rise in party polarisation in the U.S., with a particular example of the polarised U.S. Congress, where both parties consistently deviated from the ideological center. By 2014, 92% of Republicans were to the right of the median Democrat and 94% of Democrats were to the left of the median Republican, indicating an exponential gap between the two parties (Pew Research Center, 2014). What is more, Pew Research Center (2014) indicated a rise in partisan antipathy, with mutual hostilities increasing between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party, exacerbating the degree of polarisation. While the U.S. party polarisation has not always been high, with McCarty (2019) stating that the 20th century witnessed a rather low level of polarisation mostly due to a post-WWII bipartisan consensus and an absence of certain issues that are now polarising politics, it has evidently been accelerating over the past years, culminating in a rather tense and divisive U.S. presidential race of 2024. What can account for this dynamic is a complex interplay of factors, including, apart from a rise in affective polarisation and partisanship, the emergence of social and cultural issues on which the stances of Democrats and Republicans diverge. To provide an example, Vail (2014) found an explicit correlation between an increasing presence of cultural issues, such as abortion rights, within the

political discourse and a rise in polarisation in the United States. Specifically, Vail (2014) finds that the Democratic Party and the Republican Party have been experiencing a rising polarisation between 1952 and 2012 in relation to issues concerning women. Currently, the more culturally and socially divisive issues surface in the modern world, the more the parties are drifting apart, which has substantial implications for the governance of the country as the paper will further discuss.

Finally, party polarisation has far-reaching consequences for a myriad of issues and entities, including all three branches of the government, namely, executive, legislative and judicial (Lee, 2015). As such, the president, the Congress, with its House of Representatives and the Senate, as well as the Supreme Court are all, in one way or another, influenced by party polarisation. One of the most common manifestations of such party polarisation is a legislative gridlock, which represents a policy stalemate with the legislative process being suspended and the Congress being unable to pass policies, and which Jones (2001) closely associated with party polarisation. Similarly, Blackman (2016) argued that the Congress loses its power to solve major issues as its internal polarisation intensifies. These "unfavourable political winds", as stated by Young (2014, p.992), have significant consequences for both domestic policies of the U.S. and its. foreign policy. Of particular importance to this paper, however, is the effect of such party polarisation on the U.S. foreign policy formation specifically. As parties tend to take contradictory stances on a wide array of issues, ranging from climate change to the view of NATO and Ukraine, the party in power largely determines the course of the U.S. foreign policy as it sees fit. One of the most striking examples of this is the Paris Agreement which was unilaterally ratified by Barack Obama (the Democratic Party) in 2016, with Donald Trump (the Republican Party) unilaterally withdrawing from it in 2017 (Durney, 2017). On the first day of the Democratic Party return to power in

2021, however, Joseph Biden returned the United States to the Paris Agreement. This is, however, a rare case of where an executive was able to unilaterally enact a policy. In most cases, per contra, foreign policy is devised under the influence of both legislative and executive branches. The Ukraine crisis, for example, is one such case, with Pew Research Center (2024) finding an increasing partisan divergence between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party with regard to NATO and Ukraine. Particularly, Republicans view the U.S. membership in NATO more negatively than Democrats, in addition to being more negatively inclined towards giving more aid to Ukraine than the democrats (Pew Research Center, 2024). This exemplifies the impediment to the production of a coherent, unilateral response to the Ukraine crisis, dividing Democrats and Republicans as to how it should be handled as well as to what foreign policy approach should be applied vis-à-vis Russia, as the paper discusses in more detail below.

To conclude, party polarisation is a complex phenomenon that has essentially pervaded the political scene of the U.S. for years, dividing it into two ideologically diverse political camps. In recent years, however, party polarisation in the U.S. has intensified, with bipartisanship, which is a consensus between two opposing parties, becoming a virtually non-existent concept as little to no consensus can be reached between Democrats and Republicans neither on domestic nor on foreign issues. Such an intensification of party polarisation influences the operations of the government's three branches and is prone to producing a legislative gridlock, leaving the Congress suspended and unable to function properly. What is more, polarisation leads to contrasting foreign policy approaches, depending on which of the two parties is presently in power, as exemplified by the Paris Agreement and the Ukraine crisis. Therefore, it can be inferred that the U.S. party polarisation has become a truly divisive force that is determining the United States' course of action in many respects, including its foreign policy.

2.2. U.S. Party Polarisation as an Intervening Variable in the U.S. Foreign Policy

Having looked at the notion of polarisation broadly, it became evident that it represents a powerful political force that is able to influence various political agenda. More specifically, however, the ability of the U.S. party polarisation to influence the U.S. foreign policy decisions should be outlined so as to prove its applicability to the topic of foreign policy. By rendering an understanding of the precise way in which polarisation influences foreign policy decisions, this will aid in the further conduction of the research on the topic. To assist with this, the theory of neoclassical realism, which, in addition to looking at systemic incentives, takes into account domestic factors as intervening variables in the formulation of foreign policy of a state, will be applied.

Firstly, it might appear counterintuitive to take the U.S. party polarisation as a variable in the U.S. foreign policy formation due to it being a matter of domestic affairs. In spite of this fact, the U.S. party polarisation does, indeed, act as an intervening variable in formulation of the U.S. foreign policy if looked at through the prism of neoclassical realism of Rose (1998). By taking into account both systemic incentives (independent variable) and internal factors (intervening variable), neoclassical realism renders a comprehensive understanding of how the foreign policy of a state is shaped by both domestic and foreign state of affairs. As is evident in figure 1, this paper implements neoclassical realism by taking into consideration the 2022- 2024 international environment of 2022-2024 as systemic incentives (independent variable) and the U.S. party polarisation as an internal factor (intervening variable) with a view to seeing how the latter impacts the formulation of the U.S. foreign policy in relation to Russia within the context of the former. Of particular importance is the type II neoclassical realism (Ripsman et al., 2016), which is

usually associated with neoclassical realism of Rose (1998) and which highlights the cruciality of considering both internal and external factors of a state in the formulation of its foreign policy. The U.S. party polarisation, therefore, can be considered as an essential factor in the way the U.S. approaches its foreign policy.

Secondly, to showcase the role of polarisation in shaping foreign policy, it can be of great use to juxtapose the U.S. party polarisation with the U.S. bipartisan consensus in order to see the strikingly different effects the two notions have on the U.S. foreign policy. To do so, two periods from the U.S. history can be compared, with one being characterised by a bipartisan consensus and the other being characterised by polarisation between parties. Starting with an example of the former, post-WWII bipartisan consensus can be taken into consideration. As mentioned by McCarty (2019), the U.S. party polarisation was rather low in the aftermath of the Second World War owing to a consensus between two major U.S. parties (bipartisan consensus) on how affairs of the state should be approached. Similarly, according to Lynch (2018), the U.S. foreign policy stance on Russia in 2003-2004 exemplified bipartisan consensus as both Democrats and Republicans were equally hostile in relation to Russia, most prominently exemplified by their unwilligness to cooperate with the Russian president. In this case, the U.S. could produce foreign policy that was supported both by the Democratic Party and the Republican Party, without experiencing major disagreements between one another on which course of action to take.

By contrast, once parties disagree on a particular issue, holding polar opposite views on it, this polarisation impedes the decision-making process, making foreign policy either tough to implement or simply inconsistent and discontinuous. Such polarisation in the U.S. can be exemplified by the realm of environmental policy and the strikingly different views of Democrats and

Republicans on how it should be approached by the U.S. As has been briefly mentioned above, the Paris Agreement of 2015 is one of the most vivid examples of discontinuity in the U.S. foreign policy as a result of polarisation between Republicans and Democrats on the importance of climate change. Having been adopted by Barack Obama (the Democratic Party) in 2016, the Paris Agreement was left by the U.S. in 2016 as a result of an executive decree of Donald Trump (Republican Party) (Durney, 2017). While Joe Biden (the Democratic Party) later returned the U.S. to the Paris Agreement, it is evident that the U.S. party polarisation on crucial global issues indeed acts as an intervening variable in shaping the U.S. foreign policy. As such, one inference that can be made from this comparison is that the U.S. bipartisan consensus (consensus between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party) is more favourable to a coherent and rapidly-enacted foreign policy rather than polarisation between parties. While polarisation divides the parties along two divergent lines of reasoning, stalling decision-making process, bipartisan consensus offers a common ground for foreign policy formulation.

To conclude, while it might, indeed, appear that the U.S. party polarisation is a matter of domestic affairs only and, as such, should not be considered as a variable in the U.S. foreign policy formation, neoclassical realism of Rose (1998) posits otherwise. Being a prominent domestic force, the U.S. party polarisation acts as an intervening variable in the formation of the U.S. foreign policy, which renders novel insights into what domestic factors may influence the formulation of the foreign policy of a state. While bipartisan consensus provides favourable conditions for a unanimous decision-making process on foreign policy issues, polarisation between parties can severely hinder this process, making foreign policy quite discontinuous and problematic in the long-term.

2.3. Evolution of U.S.-Russia relations & U.S. Foreign Policy vis-à-vis Russia

While not always enjoying relations of mutual trust and amiability, the United States and Russia have paid particular attention to one another over the course of history for a number of reasons. At times out of fear (as during the Cold War) and at times out of a genuine desire to cooperate (as during the policy of the "reset"), the U.S. and Russia have been both historical allies and historical opponents, closely watching each other at all times. With the end of the Cold War rivalry and the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, it was supposed that Russia would integrate into the Western-led world order, effectively ending confrontational relations between the two states. This would not, however, prove to be as smooth of a transition as expected. Since the dissolution of the USSR, the nature of the relations between the U.S. and Russia had been alternating between confrontation and cooperation, with the confrontation ultimately prevailing in 2022 as a result of the Ukraine crisis. This crisis provoked a drastic shift in the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia, with the U.S.-Russia relations suffering irreparable damage, leaving the future of the U.S.-Russia relations uncertain.

Firstly, the 20th century has been instrumental in laying the foundation for the future of the U.S.-Russia relations and, as such, it is worth briefly reviewing it. While being allies during WWII that jointly defeated the Axis powers in 1945, the United States. and Russia soon ceased being partners, with the seeds of ideological rivalry having been planted not long after the Second World War ended. In the aftermath of WWII, tensions between the United States and the Soviet Union, with their respective ideologies of capitalism and communism, started to dominate their relations. In a stark departure to its previous policy of isolationism, the U.S. quickly recognised the Soviet Union (and the potential spread of communism) as a threat not only to the U.S. itself, but also to the rest of the world. This culminated in president Truman's

proclamation of the launch of the policy of containment in 1947 in the form of the Truman Doctrine (Nagar et al., 2014). From that point forward, the key foreign policy goal of the United States was to contain the Soviet Union and to prevent the spread of the communist ideology. As such, for nearly the whole second part of the 20th century, the U.S.-Russian relations were characterised by an ideological confrontation and mutual hostilities within a bipolar world order. Of particular importance to this paper is the creation of NATO during this period in response to the communist threat. From its foundation in 1949, NATO represented a military alliance of the Western states aimed at achieving collective security and containing the potential threat from the Soviet Union. Despite its initial goal having ceased to exist with the collapse of the USSR, NATO has modified its goals and operations, continuing to exist even with the birth of a new Russian state. Consequently, the creation of NATO would largely determine the nature of the U.S.-Russia relations for decades to come.

Secondly, the dissolution of the USSR in 1991 and the overall end of the Cold War marked a significant geopolitical shift and a novel stage in the U.S.-Russia relations, according to Roberts (in Tsygankov, 2018, p.237). It terminated the hostilities and the ideological rivalry between the U.S. and the Soviet Union that had permeated the international system since the end of WWII up until 1991. At the time, it was proposed by Fukuyama (1992) that the world had reached the “end of history”, where the notion of liberal democracy had supposedly emerged as the superior form of governance with no other regime being able to challenge it. In line with this reasoning, both being pro-Western, the new president of Russia, Boris Yeltsin, and the new Minister of Foreign Affairs, Andrei Kozyrev, started charting a new course for Russia, one where Russia would supposedly integrate into the Western-led world order, adopting democratic and liberal principles. Initially having started with hopes on both sides, this period of cooperation largely proved to

be unsustainable. This happened mostly due to a certain mismatch between the intentions and interests of Russia and the West, consequently leading to an ultimate failure of the Russian attempt to integrate into the West, indicating that the world was not, in fact, at "the end of history". In short, the Western hopes were that Russia would undergo an internal transformation, while Russian hopes were that the West would accept Russia as an equal partner as it is. Yet, the key turning point became the potential enlargement of NATO, which emerged as a significant point of contention and an arguable tug of war between the United States and Russia over the post-Soviet space. One of the key reasons behind this is that, according to Lynch (2016), Russia believes in its regional primacy in the post-Soviet space, with the West refusing to accept this notion. Therefore, NATO as a point of contention has been solidified in the U.S.-Russia relations, making their cooperation problematic.

Nevertheless, as the hopes that Russia would integrate into the Western-led world order have been shattered on both sides, Russia and the West, partially out of willingness and partially out of necessity, entered the 21st century with pragmatic cooperation. This manifested itself in cooperation of the U.S. and Russia in certain areas, such as counter-terrorism agenda. One of the key reasons behind this was the unprecedented terrorist attacks of September 11th, 2001 that targeted the Twin Towers in New York by a terrorist group al-Qaeda. By expressing sympathy with the U.S., Russia was determined to cooperate with it on fighting terrorism in the international system, marking a new stage in the U.S.-Russia relations. What is more, in an unparalleled move, NATO-Russia Council was created in May 2002 as a sign of both the recognition of Russia by the West as a strategic partner and the readiness of Russia to loosen its opposition to the enlargement of NATO, ultimately leading to the amelioration of relations (Franekova, 2002). At the same time, the turn that the U.S. foreign policy took with the launch of the War on Terror was at odds with Russia's view of the world order, not only effectively ending

the cooperation between the two states on the counter-terrorist agenda, but also planting the seeds of future conflicts and confrontation (German, 2024). According to German (2024), the U.S.-Russia relations had been significantly impacted by the U.S. foreign policy under the George W. Bush administration that emphasised unilateralism, spread of democracy and liberal interventionism, which would ultimately contribute to the Ukraine crisis of 2024. Prior to this, NATO emerged as a point of contention once more. The statement during the Bucharest Summit of April 2008 about Georgia and Ukraine eventually becoming members of NATO further complicated the relations between the U.S. and Russia, with the latter launching an invasion into Georgia (German, 2024). The U.S. and Russia attempted to reset their relationship in 2009-2012, with Barack Obama, president of the U.S., and Dmitry Medveded, president of Russia, focusing on bettering the relations, albeit, to little avail in the long-run, according to Roberts (in Tsygankov, 2018, p.247). With the return of Vladimir Putin to the presidency of Russia in 2012 and the renewed hostilities between the U.S. and Russia over the post-Soviet space, there was little hope for improvement in their relations. Therefore, with the clash of interests over the expansion of NATO remaining at the heart of the tensions between the U.S. and Russia, the relations between the two states ultimately soured due to the inability to resolve, among other things, the Ukraine crisis on mutually acceptable terms, leaving the U.S. and Russia locked in confrontational relations.

Distantly originating from the 2008 Bucharest Summit (and the proclamations of Ukraine potentially joining NATO), as well as from the 2013 Euromaidan (which culminated in the installation of a pro-Western government, making Ukraine joining NATO ever more likely), the question of Ukraine has long been a point of contention in the U.S.-Russia relations. As the Russian incorporation of Crimea took place in 2014, it has once again put the U.S. and Russia at loggerheads. Notably, Ukraine emerged as a polarising factor not

only in the U.S.-Russia relations, but also within the U.S. itself. American scholars differ in their views on the crisis, with realists, such as John J. Mearshimer, and liberals, such as Michael McFaul and Stephen Sestanovich, taking polar opposite views on the roots of the crisis. Particularly, Mearsheimer (2014) claims that the crisis was initially generated by a number of actions by the West, namely, the expansion of NATO and the European Union to the east, as well as the promotion of democracy outside of the West. Essentially representing a clash between the Russian proponents of realism and the Western proponents of liberalism, the Ukraine crisis, according to Mearsheimer (2014), had been generated by a reluctance of the latter to acknowledge the security concerns of the former. McFaul & Sestanovich (2014), however, in response to Mearsheimer (2014), take a polar opposite view, stating that the enlargement of NATO cannot possibly be considered as a reason behind the crisis due to it having happened a long time ago. Instead, McFaul & Sestanovich (2014) propose that it was the Russian leader's personal choice to show the U.S. in a bad light, so as to boost popularity domestically, that generated the crisis in the first place. In response to this critique, Mearsheimer (2014) points to the fact that it was this particular liberal logic that omitted the security concerns of Russia that initiated the crisis, making Russia operate out of fear. Considering such distinct views on the same crisis in academia and, as has been briefly mentioned above, the U.S. politicians are no less polarised with regard to the Ukraine crisis than the scholars, which has implications for how the U.S. approaches Russia.

It is notable that with the U.S. further intending on welcoming the post-Soviet states into NATO and Russia striving to protect its dominance in the post-Soviet space, the peak of this conflict has been reached in 2022 with Russia declaring a special military operation in Ukraine. Representing a culmination of decades-long tensions between the U.S. and Russia, the 2022 Ukraine crisis has provoked drastic changes in their respective foreign

policies towards one another, significantly impacting the nature of the U.S.-Russia relations. By effectively putting to a halt all previous attempts to cooperate as well as destroying any hopes of potential cooperation in the near future, mutually beneficial relations became a virtually unattainable goal for the two states. Essentially being locked in a confrontation, the U.S. and Russia are waging a proxy war, characterised by hybrid warfare (defined by Hoffman (2007) as a combination of non-conventional and conventional elements of warfare) and by the existential nature of the conflict (Mearsheimer, 2023). According to German (2024), the 2022 Ukraine crisis has prompted an alteration in the U.S. foreign policy approach towards Russia, effectively ending all of the previous strategies, embarking, instead, upon a strategy of directly diminishing the strategic power of Russia. Once again, however, the U.S. stance on the crisis differs due to the party polarisation over the Ukraine crisis. According to Pew Research Center (2024), the majority of Republicans state that it is not the responsibility of the U.S. to provide aid to Ukraine and support it in the crisis, while the majority of Democrats believe that the U.S. either provides sufficient support or not enough of it. Whether such polarisation, however, exudes influence on the U.S. foreign policy formation in relation to Russia is the subject of the following chapter.

In conclusion, the United States and Russia have shared a long, complex history, with their relations being fuelled, among other things, by the remnants of the Cold War rivalry. The dissolution of the USSR in 1991 supposedly had to put an end to the confrontation between the U.S. and Russia, with the latter willing to integrate into the Western-led world order. Yet, while this attempt of integration was genuinely made, a clash of interests prevailed in their relations, leading, ultimately, to the deterioration of the relations between the U.S. and Russia. One of the most prominent factors that contributed to this deterioration on numerous occasions were the strikingly divergent views of

NATO and its enlargement into the post-Soviet space. While some attempts were made to reconcile these differences (e.g. the NATO-Russia Council of 2002), the U.S. and Russia were essentially unable to reach a consensus, culminating in the 2022 Ukraine crisis.

3. U.S. Party Polarisation with regard to Ukraine Crisis & Russia

Having thoroughly analysed the concept of polarisation within the U.S. party politics and the evolution of the U.S.-Russia relations, this chapter will focus on analysing the specifics of attitudes and mentions by Democrats and Republicans of the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis and Russia in order to understand the extent of their polarisation over the issues and the extent to which it exudes influence on the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia. Below is the table of foreign policy objectives and measures, mentioned by Democrats and Republicans, that was generated via coding of the 2024 presidential debate of Kamala Harris and Donald Trump, vice presidential debate of Tim Walz and JD Vance, Democratic convention speech of Kamala Harris and Republican convention speech of Donald Trump. Prior to delving into the nuanced discussion of the results, it should be noted that while the talk of the Ukraine crisis and Russia is present on both Democratic and Republican sides, the rhetoric employed by them with regard to this topic is highly polarised. Notably, neither of the parties would like for the conflict to persist. Thus, while employing polar opposite rhetoric with regard to Ukraine and Russia, Democrats and Republicans share an implicit notion that the Ukraine crisis has to be put to a halt, albeit via different tactics. This, in turn, signifies that whether Democrats or Republicans are in power will produce different implications for the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia.

Foreign Policy Objectives & Measures

Figure 3

	Harris (debate)	Harris (speech)	Walz (debate)	Trump (debate)	Trump (speech)	Vance (debate)
Provide aid to Ukraine	1	1	0	0	0	0
Reduce aid to Ukraine	0	0	0	1	1	0
Constrain Russia	0	0	0	0	0	0
Negotiate with Russia	0	0	0	3	0	0
View on NATO and Europe (positive)	1	1	0	0	0	0
View on NATO and Europe (negative)	0	0	0	2	0	0
Resolution of the Ukraine crisis	0	0	0	4	1	0
Stakes of the Ukraine crisis	1	1	0	3	1	0

Note: the numbers in the table represent the number of times particular foreign policy objectives and measures were mentioned during the speeches.

3.1. Democratic Perspective on 2022-2024 Ukraine Crisis & Russia

Having coded the 2024 presidential and vice presidential debates in the U.S., as well as the convention speeches of Democratic and Republican nominees (figure 3, appendix A), it is now possible, as such, to proceed with analysing the way Democrats view the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis and the way they see Russia should be approached within this context. In order to do this, the method of narrative analysis, outlined in the methodological section, will be employed here to construct the narrative of Democrats with regard to the Ukraine crisis and how they see the way Russia should be approached in U.S. foreign policy.

Firstly, to briefly reiterate what has been stated above, the construction of the Democratic narrative has been done via coding the 2024 presidential debate of Kamala Harris and Donald Trump, the 2024 vice presidential debate of Tim Walz and JD Vance and the primary convention speech of Kamala Harris. The findings from figure 3 illustrate that Kamala Harris is both promoting and

supporting the provision of aid to Ukraine, with an overall positive view of NATO allies and Europe at large. While she does talk about the stakes of the crisis, which, according to her, lie in America's ability to maintain international rules and the position of the U.S. as a global leader of the liberal, democratic world, she neither explicitly mentions the resolution of the crisis nor the need to constrain Russia. Her stance on the Ukraine crisis and Russia, as such, is rather consistent and subtle. Notably, Harris is highly consistent when it comes to talking about the Ukraine crisis and Russia. Figure 3 showcases the number of times certain topics have been mentioned by Kamala Harris in both her debate and her convention speech, with her talking equally about aid to Ukraine, NATO allies and the stakes of the crisis. When it comes to the 2024 vice presidential debate, however, Tim Walz mentioned neither the Ukraine crisis nor Russia in his speech, focusing, rather, on domestic issues and the U.S. foreign policy with regard to the Middle East. It can be stated, therefore, that while Democrats do have a stance on the Ukraine crisis and Russia, believing that the former has to be supported and that the U.S. should emerge as a global leader in the crisis, they are not aggressive in their approach to the topic, avoiding overly harsh measures within the context of the U.S. presidential and vice presidential elections.

Secondly, it is now possible to construct the Democratic narrative with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia, based on the aforementioned findings, employing the narrative method outlined in the methodological section. It is quite clear that Democrats take the Ukraine crisis seriously, stressing the need to continue providing support to Ukraine so as not to let it fall. Their ultimate goals are, as such, defending democratic and liberal values, with the U.S. protecting international norms in the international system as a global leader of the democratic world. None of the Democrats, however, talk about concrete measures that they wish to take in relation to Russia so as to end the crisis that they deem to be unlawful and morally wrong. This can potentially be

explained by the emplotment of the context (figure 2) with a win-lose setting of the U.S. presidential elections, where each leader bases their line of reasoning on appealing to the civil society. Democrats, as such, are not incentivised to talk about ending the crisis. Rather, they emerge as democratic leaders, defending democratic and liberal values, as their supporters would expect them to. While Democrats have applied sanctions and international pressure on Russia so as to weaken its ability to influence Ukraine previously, they have avoided mentioning any steps they wish to take against Russia in the future. Therefore, the Democratic narrative with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia represents a rigid commitment to supporting Ukraine, thereby defending democratic and liberal ideals, while avoiding overly harsh measures due to the 2024 U.S. presidential elections being at stake.

To conclude, construction of the Democratic narrative via coding the 2024 U.S. presidential and vice presidential elections, alongside a Democratic convention speech of Kamala Harris, allowed to get an understanding of how Democrats view the Ukraine crisis and Russia. While taking a rigid stance on supporting Ukraine and providing aid, Democrats mentioned neither the steps to potentially resolve the crisis nor their foreign policy objectives towards Russia. All of these have to be considered within the win-lose context of the U.S. presidential elections, where Democrats' key goals are to defend democratic values and, ultimately, get elected.

3.2. Republican Perspective on 2022-2024 Ukraine Crisis & Russia

Having constructed and analysed the Democratic narrative with regard to Russia and the Ukraine crisis, this section will proceed with constructing and analysing the Republican narrative on the same issues. In particular, this section will use the results of coding the 2024 presidential and vice presidential debates in the U.S. as well as the Republican convention speech

of Donald Trump, presented in figure 3 and appendix A, in order to outline the Republican narrative.

Firstly, when looking at the Republican stance on the Ukraine crisis and Russia, the findings from figure 3 showcase that not only was both Ukraine and Russia mentioned by Trump in his convention speech and during the debate with the Democratic nominee Kamala Harris, but that they were also mentioned numerous times by him. Notably, Trump's convention speech was quite mild in this sense, mentioning a reduction of aid to Ukraine once, stressing the need to resolve the crisis once and highlighting the stakes involved once. During the debate with Harris, however, Trump demonstrated a more aggressive and thorough approach to the conflict, stating alike points up to four times. Not only did Trump express his unwillingness to keep sponsoring Ukraine (claiming that, instead, Europe and NATO allies should invest more, viewing NATO as underinvesting in the conflict), but he also mentioned the need to negotiate with Russia in order to resolve the conflict, blaming Democrats for not starting negotiations with Vladimir Putin. Additionally, Donald Trump has made it crystal clear that his primary goal in this conflict is to put it to an end, emphasising both his willingness as well as his ability to do so. On top of that, Trump has raised a point about the stakes involved in this conflict multiple times, stating that it can potentially lead to WWIII and a nuclear catastrophe if mishandled. Similarly to the Democratic vice presidential nominee Tim Walz, however, neither the topic of the Ukraine crisis nor Russia's involvement in it was mentioned by JD Vance during the vice presidential debates. Still, it is evident from the key line of Republicans' reasoning, laid out by Trump during the debate and the Republican Convention speech, that the Ukraine crisis and Russia are, indeed, on the agenda of Republicans, who deem it crucial to resolve the conflict as soon as possible.

Secondly, based on the aforementioned findings it is not possible to proceed with revealing the Republican narrative with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia via the implementation of the narrative analysis, laid out in the methodological section. As is evident from the findings, Republicans take a relatively harsh approach to the crisis, emphasising both the need to put it to an end as well as the need to reduce the role the U.S. plays in supporting Ukraine. Both of these goals correspond with Republicans' ultimate stake of winning the U.S. presidential elections, as both the former and the latter will aid in freeing up resources and reorienting them to what Republicans view as top foreign policy concerns (such as illegal immigration and a trade war with China), as well as in preventing a potential WWIII and nuclear disaster. Republicans are willing to do so via conducting negotiations with Vladimir Putin of Russia, emphasising that Democrats were not prone to doing so since the very start of the conflict. Thus, the Republican narrative with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia highlights the need to resolve the conflict as soon as possible, both engaging Russia in a diplomatic dialogue as well as reducing the provision of the U.S. support to Ukraine, with an ultimate goal of shifting the U.S. focus on other foreign policy concerns that Republicans deem to be more crucial.

In conclusion, the aforementioned reconstruction of the Republican narrative with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia via coding the 2024 presidential and vice presidential debates, as well as the Republican Convention speech of Donald Trump rendered a nuanced understanding of the way Republicans view the issues at hand. In particular, Republicans take the need to resolve the Ukraine crisis seriously. Believing it to be in the best interest of the U.S. and the world at large, they stress the need to negotiate with Russia in reaching a deal to settle the crisis, cautioning against a potential eruption of WWII and a nuclear catastrophe. Once settled, however, Republicans believe that the U.S.

will be able to reorient its resources to other foreign policy concerns, which Republicans deem to be more vital to the national interest of the U.S.

3.3. 2022-2024 Ukraine Crisis as a Polarising Factor in U.S. Foreign Policy towards Russia

Taking into consideration all of the aforementioned findings, including the Democratic and the Republican narratives, it is now possible to proceed with analysing them via juxtaposing the two narratives. Such juxtaposition will aid in answering the research question of "to what extent do the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge with regard to the current Ukraine crisis and how, if at all, did it influence the formation of the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis in 2022-2024?" as well as to test the initial hypothesis of "the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge significantly with regard to the Ukraine crisis, with this discrepancy being a prominent intervening variable in the formation of the U.S foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis."

Firstly, in comparing the Democratic and the Republican narratives vis-à-vis the Ukraine crisis and Russia, it is evident that they differ in their approach to both Ukraine and Russia. The Democratic narrative expresses full support of Ukraine, advocating for provision of aid to Ukraine and viewing NATO as a key ally with which the U.S. should jointly work when it comes to the crisis. What is essentially at stake here, from the point of view of Democrats, is the image of the U.S. as a leader of the democratic, liberal world that is able to protect these values around the globe. The Republican narrative, by contrast, disregards the provision of aid to Ukraine and deems it necessary for NATO to invest more in the crisis, with the U.S. reorienting its resources to other foreign policy concerns, such as illegal immigration and a trade war with China. Republicans believe that the stakes of the crisis are rather high,

pointing to a potential WWIII and a nuclear disaster. When it comes to the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia in this context, the Democratic and the Republican narratives diverge once more. While they were not mentioning Russia during the presidential race, Democrats omit the possibility of holding talks with Russia to resolve the crisis. While not explicitly stated, it can be presumed that the Democratic narrative does not allow for negotiations to take place when the crisis has already greatly escalated. The Republican narrative, however, emphasises negotiations with Russia as a key to resolving the crisis. In addition to being willing to hold talks with Russia, Republicans stress their resolve to end the crisis as soon as possible. It should be acknowledged that these differences present in the rhetoric influence the U.S. foreign policy. One inference that can be made from this is that the rhetoric used by Democrats and Republicans with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia differs substantially, pointing to their polar opposite stances on the way the crisis should be approached which influences the foreign policy of the U.S.

Secondly, such a striking difference between the two narratives corresponds with what Oppermann & Spencer in Mello & Ostermann (2023) classify as competing narratives. According to Oppermann & Spencer in Mello & Ostermann (2023), competing narratives presuppose distinct interpretations of a foreign policy of a state, locking the two sides not only in a confrontation but also in a competition for superior influence in the foreign policy discourse. In addition to the aforementioned clashes between the Democratic and the Republican narrative, a lot of mutual accusations and a constant blame game (as mentioned in figure 2, emplotment) were found during the coding of the speeches of Democrats and Republicans. Ideological polarisation, as such, is quite prevalent between the Democratic and the Republican parties, with affective polarisation also contributing to the divide between them. On top of that, partisanship plays a crucial role in the

contemporary U.S. party polarisation, where elections themselves are becoming more of an attack on the opposing party rather than being a chance to showcase the party's own positions, interests and objectives.

Finally, it is now possible to provide an answer to the proposed research question and to test the initial hypothesis. Taking all of the aforementioned findings into consideration, it can be concluded that the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge significantly with regard to the Ukraine crisis and this has major implications for how the U.S. approaches Russia in its foreign policy. Thus, as the Democratic and the Republican narratives differ with regard to Russia, with the latter being willing to negotiate with it and the former refraining from negotiations, this has an impact on the course of the foreign policy of the U.S. towards Russia. The hypothesis, therefore, is proven as the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party do diverge significantly with regard to the Ukraine crisis, with this discrepancy being a prominent intervening variable in the formation of the U.S foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis. It should be acknowledged, however, that even if Republicans do decide to embark upon negotiations with Russia concerning the Ukraine crisis, it is highly doubtful that the economic sanctions imposed on Russia will be lifted. As such, it may be said that the tone with which Democrats and Republicans approach Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis does differ and that this changes the substance of the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia.

To conclude, when compared, the Democratic and the Republican narratives differ substantially when it comes to the Ukraine crisis and the approach to Russia. While Democrats are in favour of supporting Ukraine and working closely with NATO to provide help, Republicans are more averse to the provision of aid, stressing, on the other hand, the need to negotiate with

Russia to reach a deal**.** As such competing narratives encompass polar opposite views, fueled, among other things, by mutual animosity and partisanship, this has major influence on the formation of the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia. Still, it should be noted that while Republicans may be more prone to negotiations with Russia than Democrats, Russia still faces a plethora of sanctions and a general exclusion from the Western world.

4.Research Results & Concluding Remarks

4.1. Research Results

This paper had set out to trace the influence of the U.S. party polarisation on the U.S. foreign policy formation in relation to Russia within the context of the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis. This was primarily done via applying the lens of neoclassical realism (Rose, 1998) and the method of narrative analysis in order to understand the way the U.S. party polarisation could shift the U.S. approach to Russia. As a result of the research, it was found that Democrats and Republicans do, indeed, view the approach to both Ukraine and Russia differently**,** which has implications for the way the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia is implemented.

Initially, having conducted a nuanced overview of the previous literature on the topic, the following research question was formulated: To what extent do the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party with regard to the Ukraine crisis diverge and how, if at all, did it influence the formation of the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the current Ukraine crisis in 2022-2024? With the hypothesis being that the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge significantly with regard to the Ukraine crisis, with this discrepancy having been a prominent intervening variable in the formation of the U.S foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis between 2022-2024. In order to answer the proposed research question and to test the hypothesis, the method of narrative analysis was used to reconstruct the Democratic and the Republican narratives with regard to the Ukraine crisis and Russia. It was found that the Democratic narrative presupposes a constant flow of aid to Ukraine and the U.S. working closely with NATO to help Ukraine as a leader of the liberal, democratic world. The Republican narrative, by contrast, criticises the U.S. involvement in the crisis, stating that, instead, NATO countries should be responsible for providing aid to Ukraine, not the U.S. As

for the foreign policy approach to Russia, Republicans advocate for holding negotiations with the Russian president in order to resolve the crisis that the Republicans deem to be rather dangerous. While it was, indeed, found that the Democratic and the Republican narratives diverge significantly with regard to both Russia and Ukraine, this divergence goes beyond pure rhetoric used by both Republicans and Democrats, influencing the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia.

In answering the research question, taking all of the aforementioned points into consideration, it can be stated that the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge significantly with regard to the Ukraine crisis, yet this has little implications for how the U.S. approaches Russia in its foreign policy. The hypothesis, as such, was proven as the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party diverge significantly with regard to the Ukraine crisis, with this discrepancy being a prominent intervening variable in the formation of the U.S foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis. For now, as such, Ukraine does act as a polarising factor within the U.S. political scene, influencing the U.S. approach to Russia. While Republicans express their willingness to negotiate with Russia, they do not, however, mention revoking sanctions or ameliorating bilateral relations with Russia. One inference that can be made from this is that the case of Russia leads to polarisation between Democrats and Republicans, producing different foreign policy initiatives, yet, some aspects, such as those concerning sanctions, remain the same.

To conclude, it was initially hypothesised that the polar opposite views of Democrats and Republicans on the Ukraine crisis and Russia influence the U.S. foreign policy to a significant extent. The research that was subsequently conducted to test this hypothesis proved it to be true. In particular, it was found that as the Democratic and the Republican narratives do diverge,

presenting competing narratives, this influences the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the 2022-2024 Ukraine crisis.

4.2. Discussion

When it comes to further relevance and applicability, this study is intended to contribute to the existing literature on the U.S. party polarisation, the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia and the Ukraine crisis in 2022-2024, to advance understanding of the U.S. party polarisation's influence on the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia as well as to generate further research on the aforementioned topics.

Taking into account the fact that this paper contains an extensive literature review on the components of the research topic and a nuanced research of the U.S. party polarisation, this paper may shed light on some aspects of the concept of polarisation and its multifaceted nature. When it comes to the U.S.-Russia relations, this paper incorporates a broad historical overview of the U.S.-Russia relations, highlighting the economic, political and cultural decoupling of the U.S. and Russia as well as an end to the cyclical relations that the two states previously experienced. When combined, the research into the U.S. party polarisation and the U.S.-Russia relations may render a greater comprehension of how the U.S. approaches Russia within the context of the Ukraine crisis. Particularly, this paper draws attention to the importance of rhetoric and its potential to shift paradigms and to translate into the foreign policy of a state. The paper, as such, contributes not only to the body of literature on polarisation per se, but also to the literature on the relations between the U.S. and Russia and the way the U.S. party polarisation may influence them.

What is more, this paper highlights the fact that while Democrats and Republicans are, indeed, polarised over the Ukraine crisis, none of the sides

wish to prolong this conflict. On the contrary, both Republicans and Democrats view tackling the crisis as being existential to the core national interest of the U.S., albeit for different reasons. Nonetheless, the superior aim of this study is to prompt Republicans and Democrats to see past their differences and reach a bipartisan consensus on tackling the Ukraine crisis. As history shows, it is a bipartisan consensus in the U.S. that usually produces the most efficient results. By combining their powers, tactiques and measures, as such, Democrats and Republicans may produce an effective response to the crisis.

In conclusion, not only does this study at contributing to the existing literature on the topic and generating further discussion in the academic world, but it also hopes to highlight the fact that Democrats and Republicans are closer to a unanimous stance on the Ukraine crisis than it appears. While employing polar opposite rhetoric, neither Democrats nor Republicans wish to continue with the crisis as it is.

4.3. Shortcomings & Limitations

To expand on the shortcomings and limitations mentioned in the methodological part, this section will outline key drawbacks of the study that have emerged while conducting the research, as well as those that have become apparent after its completion. Among such limitations are the inability to directly establish a causal relationship between the researched variables and a lack of data on some of the aspects of the research.

Firstly, as was mentioned in the methodological part, a causal relationship between the U.S. party polarisation and the changes in the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia may not be directly established due to a plethora of other factors that may be at play here. While it was concluded that the polarisation between parties does influence the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia, this

limitation still proves to be true for the way rhetoric may or may not influence the U.S. foreign policy in general. Considering the fact that the Democratic narrative and the Republican narrative are strikingly different from each other, holding polar opposite views on both the Ukraine crisis and Russia, it would still be problematic to trace the effect of such rhetoric on the U.S. foreign policy initiatives in detail.

Secondly, it was presupposed that a potential problem of the study would be a lack of data due to the chronological framework that spans recent years (2022-2024). While the 2024 presidential elections in the U.S. provided abundant resources for conducting research on the U.S. party polarisation, it was, indeed, challenging to find information on the U.S. foreign policy decisions and tactics in relation to Russia in the public domain. On top of that, it is yet to be seen how the difference between Republicans and Democrats in power influences the approach to both Russia and Ukraine in the coming years, with the current research providing a theoretical background.

Finally, another limitation of this study lies in presenting the views of the Democratic Party and the Republican Party on the basis of only four people who delivered speeches, representing their respective parties. While it may be argued that the presidential elections present the most vivid agglomeration of views of each party in the U.S., it can still be said that such a generalisation may limit the scope and depth of the study.

To conclude, the research paper does face some limitations which involve the inability to directly establish a causal relationship between the key researched variables (namely, between the U.S. party polarisation and the changes in the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia), a general lack of data on the concrete foreign policy initiatives of the U.S. in relation to Russia due to the researched crisis being a recent and ongoing one as well as a certain

generalisation of Democratic and Republican views on the basis of speeches only four people who represent these parties.

5. Conclusion

To sum it all up, the U.S. and Russia share a rich, eventful history, going from being allies during WWII to being primary opponents during the Cold War that spanned nearly half of the 20th century. The subsequent dissolution of the USSR in 1991 ushered in a seemingly new era of the U.S.-Russia relations, with the latter being eager to integrate into the Western-led order. Yet, while initial hopes were high, the following period of the U.S.-Russia relations would become filled with tensions and numerous points of contention, such as the role of NATO, the dominance over the post-Soviet space and, of particular importance to this paper, Ukraine. The 2022 Ukraine crisis would become a true watershed moment in the U.S.-Russia relations, marking their economic, political and cultural decoupling, and laying the foundation for a novel world order. Notably, the crisis has divided not only Russia and the U.S. on a state level, but also Democrats and Republicans within the U.S. on a domestic level. This paper is dedicated to such polarisation between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party, and its influence on the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the 2022 Ukraine crisis.

Starting from the dissolution of the USSR in 1991, the U.S. and Russia shared mutually amicable relations for a period of time. Yet, by the turn of the 21st century the relations gradually started to sour as both sides were diverging rapidly in their stances on numerous issues. One of the key points of contention between the U.S. and Russia that would resurface time and time again was NATO and its role in the new geopolitical reality in which the communist threat from the Soviet Union was absent, yet in which Russia was not fully accepted by the West. While the NATO-Russia Council, founded in 2002, implied an unprecedented degree of cooperation between Russia, NATO and the U.S., this period of cooperation would not last for long, with NATO and the post-Soviet space reemerging as points of contention. Particularly, the Bucharest Summit of April 2008 and the proclamation of

Georgia and Ukraine becoming members of NATO at some point aggravated Russia. While the U.S. and Russia attempted to ameliorate their bilateral relations with the policy of 'reset' in 2009-2012 under the Obama administration in the U.S. and Dmitry Medvedev of Russia, this policy would ultimately fail in the following years. Yet, with the return of Vladimir Putin in 2012 as the head of Russia, tensions over NATO reemerged in the U.S.-Russia relations, with the Russian occupation of Crimea in 2014 becoming a turning point in their relations. Still, the 2022 Ukraine crisis would be an even greater turning point in the bilateral relations of the U.S. and Russia, setting them on a course to an economic, political and cultural decoupling that had arguably not been seen since the end of the Cold War. The relations between the U.S. and Russia, as such, have undergone numerous transformations in their respective foreign policies towards one another since the dissolution of the USSR in 1991, ultimately resulting in a clash of interests over the 2022 Ukraine crisis.

Considering the fact that the ideological gap between the Democratic Party and the Republican Party has been increasing rapidly in the past years, the recent surge in the U.S. polarisation between the Democratic party and the Republican Party has implications for the U.S.-Russia relations, yet, even more so, for the 2022 Ukraine crisis. As the relations between the U.S. and Russia deteriorated after the start of the 2022 Ukraine crisis, Democrats and Republicans took opposing stances on the crisis, further complicating the already strenuous relations between the U.S. and Russia. The paper, as such, aimed not only at researching polarisation between the Democratic party and the Republican party in the U.S. per se, but also at tracing the influence of their polarisation on the U.S. foreign policy towards Russia within the context of the 2022 Ukraine crisis. To do this, the theoretical framework of neoclassical realism by Rose (1998) was applied, where the U.S. party polarisation acted as an intervening variable in the U.S. foreign policy

formation in relation to Russia. On top of that, the method of narrative analysis was implemented in order to reconstruct the Democratic narrative and the Republican narrative with the subsequent juxtaposition of them to one another. Ultimately, it was found that the Democratic and Republican narratives do diverge in relation to the Ukraine crisis and Russia, as exemplified by the coding of a number of speeches and debates, and so does the approach that Democrats and Republicans take vis-à-vis both Russia and Ukraine. In particular, the Democratic narrative presupposes a commitment to supporting Ukraine and working alongside NATO to help Ukraine in the crisis. Such an approach, as is evident from the research, is mostly driven by the need to defend the U.S. as a global leader of the democratic and liberal world and to not let Ukraine fall. By contrast, the Republican narrative emphasises the need to stop providing support to Ukraine, urging both Europe and NATO to invest in the crisis. Simultaneously, however, Republicans stress the cruciality of resolving the crisis as soon as possible, pointing to the need to negotiate with Russia to resolve the crisis, with both of these notions being absent from the Democratic narrative. This Republican approach is driven by their eagerness to reorient the resources from the Ukraine crisis to the issues that they view to be more vital to the U.S. national interest such as illegal immigration and a trade war with China. It is evident, as such, that Republicans and Democrats hold polar opposite views on the Ukraine crisis and how it should be approached. Moreover, they differ on their view of Russia and the way it should be approached within the context of the crisis. While Democrats omit mentioning negotiations with Russia or any measures that they wish to take in relation to it, Republicans highlight the importance of holding negotiations to resolve the crisis. As such, one inference that can be made from this is that the U.S. party polarisation plays a key role in the way the U.S. approaches Russia in its foreign policy. While sanctions may not be lifted under either Democrats or Republicans, it is evident that under the Republican leadership the U.S. and Russia will start a dialogue about

resolving the crisis, while under the Democratic leadership Russia will most likely not be included in the negotiations. Whichever scenario plays out, this paper aims at highlighting the fact that neither Democrats nor Republicans wish to continue with the crisis as it is. If both sides are willigning to acknowledge this, they will be able to see past their differences. In doing so, they may pool their resources to produce a joint effort in resolving the crisis, which will bring everyone closer to peace.

On a final note, it can be stated that the bilateral relations between the U.S. and Russia have undergone numerous changes over the past couple of decades, alternating between confrontation and cooperation time and time again. While both states were willing to ameliorate their relations on multiple occasions, from the foundation of the NATO-Russia Council in 2002 to the policy of 'reset' between 2009 and 2012, these attempts ultimately failed to produce durable and sustainable cooperative relations. Instead, such points of contention as the role of NATO, the post-Soviet space, and Ukraine in particular, have permeated their relations, leading to a rapid deterioration after the start of the 2022 Ukraine crisis. Not only did the crisis divide the U.S. and Russia, however, as the U.S. domestic political landscape also became divided with regard to this topic. Particularly, the Democratic Party and the Republican Party took opposing stances on Ukraine and Russia, further aggravating the bilateral relations between the U.S. and Russia. While the U.S.-Russia relations suffered seemingly irreparable damage under the Democratic leadership within the context of the 2022 Ukraine crisis, it is yet to be seen how the story will unfold under the Republican leadership. While the Republican narrative points to a softer approach towards Russia, being willing to negotiate the details of the Ukraine crisis and its resolution, only time will show if this manifests. Nonetheless, whether the U.S. and Russia manage to repair their bilateral relations or not, and whether this will contribute to the resolution of the Ukraine crisis or not, one thing that is

mostly certain is that the world is arguably as divided as it has never been before and that polarisation, be it between different parties or between different states, is proliferating, and, as such, is worth the attention of the academia.

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